



Prague, famed for its architecturally diverse castle district shown above, became the capital of the newly formed Czech Republic. The castle is the official seat of the Czech head of state.

THE SINGLE MARKET CAME INTO FORCE across European Union (EU) countries in January. It gave greater freedom to citizens of member states to live and work in other EU countries and paved the way for a single currency, **the Euro**.

On January 1, **Czechoslovakia was split into Slovakia and the Czech Republic**, dissolving the 74-year-old federation. The creation of the Czech Republic, with its capital in Prague, and Slovakia, with its capital in Bratislava, became known as the "Velvet Divorce" following the Velvet Revolution (see 1989).

Russian president **Boris Yeltsin** (1931–2007) faced mounting

opposition to his "**shock therapy**" program of reforms, which he had initiated in 1992. The measures were aimed at loosening the state's grip on the economy and moving towards a market-driven model, but they were widely regarded as being capitalist and "Western." The Russian parliament tried to impeach Yeltsin, who responded with a decree **dissolving the parliament** on September 21.

Under increasing pressure from his political opponents, Yeltsin ordered parliamentarians to vacate the parliament building. When they refused, Yeltsin ordered the army to seize the building.

A series of **bomb blasts rocked** India's financial capital **Mumbai** (formerly Bombay) on March 12, killing 257 people and injuring 713 others. They were carried out by an underworld crime syndicate.

The **Irish Republican Army** (IRA) exploded a **massive bomb** in the **City of London**, the economic heart of the English capital, on 24 April. This came a month after an IRA blast in Warrington, which killed two children. Later in the year, on December 15, the leaders of Northern Ireland and Britain signed a peace declaration, aiming to end violence in the province.

Moves toward peace were also underway between **Israel** and the

187
KILLED

437
WOUNDED

Coup casualties

Russian president Boris Yeltsin seized absolute authority by storming the parliament in Moscow, ending a rebellion by hardline opponents.

Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO). They signed the **Oslo Accords** in Washington, DC in the presence of the US president Bill Clinton in September. Aimed at mutual recognition, the accords were preceded by secret talks between the two parties, encouraged by the Norwegian government.

On April 19, a **siege** at the headquarters of a US religious sect, the Branch Davidian, near Waco, Texas killed at least 70 people, including its leader, **David Koresh**, when it ended in a fire. The Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) had surrounded the building since February, when four agents with the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, and Firearms (ATF) were killed while trying to arrest Koresh for illegally possessing firearms.

Mostar Bridge

A 16th-century bridge spanned the Neretva River for 427 years before it was destroyed during the fighting between Croats and Muslims.



Refugees flee the civil war in Rwanda and head for refugee camps in Zaire.

IN SOUTH AFRICA, ZULUS AND AFRICAN NATIONAL CONGRESS

(ANC) supporters clashed on March 28—more than 18 people were killed. The Zulus were responding to calls by their leaders to boycott the forthcoming national elections. The elections went ahead, and on May 10, **Nelson Mandela** became **South Africa's first black president** after more than three centuries of white rule. His party, the ANC (see panel, opposite), won 252 of the 400 seats in the **first democratic elections** in South Africa's history.

Elsewhere in Africa, the president of Rwanda, **Juvénal Habyarimana** (b.1937), a Hutu, was killed when his **plane was shot down** above Kigali airport on April 6. The incident catalyzed a **mass genocide**. Between April and June, about **800,000 Rwandans were killed**, most of them Tutsis killed by Hutus.

On July 1, PLO chairman **Yasser Arafat** (1929–2004) returned to the **Gaza Strip** after **27 years in exile**. It marked the start of the enactment of the Declaration of Principles agreed at the Oslo Accords, signed in Washington, DC the previous year (see 1993).

Israel and **Jordan** signed a historic peace deal on October 26, **ending 46 years of war**. US president Bill Clinton witnessed the treaty between Israeli prime minister Yitzhak Rabin (1922–95) and King Hussein at a ceremony in Wadi Araba, on the Israel–Jordan border.

On August 31, the **IRA declared a ceasefire** after 25 years of

